

Bollywood Divas

They're getting more rounded roles, fatter pay cheques, more media mileage and the brands to endorse. The women who rule Mumbai movies are ready to be taken seriously.

Aishwarya Rai Bachchan, 36

From a pretty pin-up, she has emerged as the favourite of our finest directors, from Mani Ratnam to Sanjay Leela Bhansali.

There are only three ages for women in Hollywood—Babe, District Attorney, and Driving Miss Daisy. That's what Goldie Hawn once said. Very few women in Bollywood have proved that cynical comment wrong. Madhuri Dixit could not move audiences into returning to theatres for *Aaja Nachle* after having once been dubbed the female Amitabh Bachchan with powerful performances in middling movies such as *Beta* and *Raja* while Sridevi, who once shimmered sensuously in *Mr India* and chattered endlessly in *Chaalbaaz*, is still pondering a return. Could the tide for women be changing even as society becomes more accepting of eternal youth and life begins at 40? The careers of Kajol, who made her debut in 1992 with *Bekhudi*, and Aishwarya Rai Bachchan, who kicked off her movie career in 1997 with *Iruvar*, are pointers to the greater longevity of women. Neither has had a conventional career, with the former taking a break to have and raise her daughter and the latter trying to establish herself globally. The next generation, who made their debuts in the new millennium, may also fulfil

that promise, as they experiment with commerce and art. Kareena Kapoor and Priyanka Chopra have shown the talent to match their ambition, a desire to work with the new gurus of filmmaking, and to finesse their craft in the company of cutting edge co-

Kajol, 35

Once known just for her unibrow, the actor is still the first choice for leading filmmakers like Karan Johar and Aditya Chopra.

